



Leadership in today's world

An introduction to Agile Leadership

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Leadership in today's world

An introduction to Agile Leadership

In our fast-changing modern world, building and maintaining a thriving organization is a huge challenge, no matter the company's size. While it has always been necessary for managers and leaders to understand the business itself very well, today there are additional challenges. Organizations need to be adaptable, innovative, and engaging for people. In order to be successful in the new environment, a leader not only needs to learn a lot, but unlearn old paradigms that could be holding them back. To nurture successful teams and organizations, new and different behaviors, skills and tools are needed. This is where agile leadership can make a meaningful impact.

What is Agile Leadership?

But what does the term actually mean? Taken by themselves, each of the key terms carries specific significance that together make up what is understood as agile leadership. Agile is an adjective, not a verb. It is not something you do, implement, or deploy, it is something you are. It is a property of a system, whether an individual, a team, or an entire organization. There's a reason the word is exemplified by an athlete: being agile is about flexibility, and the ability to respond quickly to unforeseen circumstances.

The Oxford dictionary defines leadership as “the action of leading a group of people or an organization”. From this perspective, leadership is not something connected to a formal role, and it is not something people are either born with or not. All of us can be leaders and followers in different contexts. Leadership is simply a capability to grow.

Agile leadership is the ability to be flexible, use different approaches, and adapt to the context and the people involved. Because of this dependence on context, expectations and relationships, there are no leadership behaviors that are inherently positive or negative. Rather, there are leadership behaviors which are more or less appropriate within the context.

Agile leadership is about the ability to make sense of the circumstances and adopt behaviors which are coherent with what people you are leading feel comfortable with. Incoherent behaviors are those that are not helpful within a specific situation and might be perceived negatively in the given context. For this reason, agile leadership is not only useful for agile organizations, but for any organization hoping to succeed in today's climate.

Coherent vs incoherent leadership

Just like a sportsman needs to master many techniques to become really flexible, a true agile leader has to master multiple leadership styles to be able to adopt the one that fits the specific context. That is quite a challenge, since we all feel more comfortable with one or two specific leadership approaches and generally find others harder. If you do not practice styles you are less comfortable with, the risk to demonstrate incoherent leadership is very high, which can be more harmful than you think.

In some organizations, people are used to being told what to do. They have learned to be comfortable with it, because they are rewarded for following directives. If one day the manager comes in and says, “Now we are agile, so you are self-organized and empowered to do what you think is most appropriate”, people will stare at each other wondering what this might mean, thinking “Just tell us what to do and we will do it”.

This is an example of incoherent leadership. The resulting frustration and dissatisfaction are known as motivational debt. Even if a specific leadership behavior seems appropriate to a situation, it needs to fit the expectations of the people involved and the culture in which they are used to operating. If it does not, it will very likely cause a negative emotional response and potentially increase motivational debt. In some cases, the impact can be so severe that people decide to leave. The Great Resignation, the elevated rate at which employees started to voluntarily quit their jobs beginning in early 2021, is a great example of what can happen in an extreme case of incoherent leadership combined with people being forced to re-evaluate life priorities

So, while it is true that agile organizations are built upon autonomous and self-managed teams, this shift cannot be pushed onto people overnight. Individuals and teams need to be gently guided over time into becoming more autonomous and agile, by adapting the leadership and the environment iteratively and incrementally, in the service of making people the best version of themselves.

Servant Leadership

The future of work has arrived faster than we could have imagined in our post-pandemic world. One of the defining characteristics of this modern workplace is a shift away from traditional decision-making hierarchies. In today's workplace, it makes more sense for decisions to be made by those individuals closest to the problem at hand. Teams are self-managed, meaning they decide what to work on, when to work on it, and how to best achieve the desired outcome. This shift comes with new demands on leadership, and effective leaders cultivate the values of servant leadership.

Expectations on leaders have shifted along with these changes. The very best leaders are not telling anyone what to do. Instead, they are removing impediments, aligning stakeholders, building relationships, coaching, providing feedback, developing people's skills and growing the capabilities of the organization. They create the conditions for individuals and teams to perform at their best.

What is servant leadership?

Servant leadership is a leadership philosophy and a set of practices in which the leader puts the needs of the employees first and helps people develop themselves and excel. Robert K. Greenleaf first popularized the term servant leadership in *The Servant as Leader*, an essay published in 1970.

The term might sound like an oxymoron the first time you hear it. You may think that the teams are there to serve the leaders, but in fact, organizations can benefit more when things are the other way around. A servant leader should be asking themselves, "Do my actions help those I lead grow as individuals? Do they, because of my actions, become healthier, wiser, freer, more autonomous, more likely to become leaders themselves?"

The virtues of servant leaders

According to Greenleaf, servant leaders cultivate eleven key virtues. These virtues are maybe even more essential now than they were in 1970. In the current world, leaders can't be effective without trust from people they are supposed to lead, and these virtues ultimately build trust.

Awareness

They have a keen sense for what is happening around them.



They know what's going on and will rarely be fooled by appearances.

The virtues of servant leaders

Calling

They are willing to sacrifice egocentric interests for the benefit of others. They have a natural calling to serve, which cannot be taught.



Community

They believe that an organization needs to function as a community. They instill a spirit of community in the workplace.



Healing

They have appreciation for the emotional health and spirit of others. They are good at facilitating a healing process of relationships, when necessary.



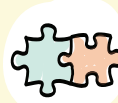
Foresight

They are able to anticipate future events. They are adept at picking up patterns in the environment and seeing what the future will bring. They can anticipate consequences of decisions with great accuracy.



Conceptualization

They have the ability to conceptualize the world, events and possibilities. They encourage others to dream great dreams and avoid getting bogged down by day-to-day realities and operations.



Listening

They are receptive and genuinely interested in the views and input of others.



Growth

They believe that all people have something to offer beyond their tangible contributions. They work hard to help people in a number of ways.



Persuasiveness

They are able to convince others to do things, rather than relying on formal authority. They never force others to do things.



Stewardship

They show a desire to prepare the organization to contribute to the greater good of society, making a positive difference in the future.



Empathy

They understand and empathize with others' circumstances and problems



How to build trust as a servant leader

One of the most effective ways to build trust is to demonstrate that you truly care about people and you are committed to their growth. Most people want to feel they are valued as individuals; that they are heard and not judged. Ultimately, it is about making the workplace more humane and fit for human beings. Servant leadership is necessary to build leadership as a diffused organizational capability, or in other words, to make everyone a potential leader.

The challenges of servant leadership

It is really difficult for managers who have learned all they know in a traditional environment to change their fundamental leadership beliefs. They might be scared to let things go, or insecure because they don't yet know how to contribute in a new and different way. They might be afraid to become useless or redundant, and they might feel lost since they might have never seen a real example of servant leadership themselves. A lot of the feedback they receive is what not to do, but there aren't always great resources to help them discover what to do. Finally, managers might be so used to pushing their ideas and instructions onto their teams, that they end up pushing and forcing these new ideas too fast, with the unintended consequence of frustration and dissatisfaction of the people involved.

How to practice a servant leadership approach

The following behaviors can help leaders understand and practice a servant leadership approach:

- Listen to your fears with compassion and ask a coach or peer to support you with trying different behavioral patterns, one at a time
- Visualize the benefits of applying those behavioral patterns, for example asking for feedback through storytelling
- Build mutual trust between management and teams, for instance by being present where the work happens and practicing MBWAL (Management By Walking Around and Listening) instead of MBSR (Management By Status Report)
- Encourage peer support and peer feedback among leaders - things are less difficult if done together

Emotional Intelligence in the Workplace

Practicing the virtues of servant leadership helps develop effective leadership in this fast-changing world. But what other qualities does an agile leader need to have?

If you want to become the kind of leader who masters multiple leadership behaviors and is able to read the situation and use an approach that is coherent to the context, you might want to develop your emotional intelligence.

Daniel Goleman was the first to popularize the idea of emotional intelligence and demonstrate evidence of its impact within organizations. He passionately argued for recognizing the relationship between someone's emotional state and the actions driven by it, and how those actions in turn impact others and the organization (essentially the people they work with), whether positively or negatively.

Emotional intelligence consists of four fundamental skills

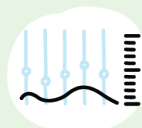
Self-awareness

Self-awareness is the ability to read and understand your own emotions as well as recognize their impact on work performance and relationships. It also includes the ability to realistically evaluate your strengths and limitations.



Self-management

Self-management is the ability to keep disruptive emotions and impulses under control, consistently display integrity and manage yourself and your responsibilities. It also includes the skill to adjust to changing situations and a readiness to seize opportunities.



Social awareness

Social awareness is the ability to sense other people's emotions, understand their perspective, and take an active interest in their concerns. It is also the ability to read the currents of organizational life, build decision networks, and navigate politics.



Social skills

These are the abilities to inspire, influence and develop others, de-escalate conflicts and facilitate resolutions. These include skills of listening and sending clear, convincing, and well-tuned messages, as well as cultivating and maintaining a web of relationships.



Emotional intelligence in leaders

These are all essential qualities for leaders, even though not everyone seems to realize it. Many organizations still use a fundamentally wrong metaphor to describe how work functions. We keep thinking of our organizations as machines, where defined inputs are transformed into defined outputs, through defined processes and well designed connections of cogs. Is this the real nature of our organizations? How can such a machine adapt to ever changing circumstances and market needs?

We will have better chances at building agile and flexible organizations, which are more equipped to succeed in the world today, if we start describing them as living organisms. Organizations are networks of people, and human beings are not interchangeable and programmable machines. It is impossible to force things on people, but good things can be achieved by leveraging people's natural talents and their intrinsic willingness to do a good job.

Effective leadership is more of a social activity than an engineering task.

How do you increase your emotional intelligence?

Here are some simple tools for growing your emotional intelligence:

- Journaling is the practice of keeping record of personal thoughts, feelings, insights connected to certain events, through handwriting, typing or even drawing. Regular journaling helps strengthen self-awareness: it is useful to spot our triggers and understand their impact on work performance and relationships, as well as keep disruptive emotions under control
- Self-reflection helps conceptualize experience and learn how to apply successful patterns to similar contexts or dampen ineffective behaviors
- Peer feedback originates from trusted peers based on observations: it is a precious resource to address improvement areas which we are unable to become aware of by ourselves
- 360° feedback is feedback from many peers, leaders, and colleagues, rather than a single manager in a top-down approach. It can be very helpful to learn how to sense other peoples' emotions and understand their perspective

Agile Leadership Principles

Many leaders trying to create more agile organizations share a sense of frustration for the many “don’ts” they were prescribed – and too few “dos”.

These leaders were constantly hearing things like, “Don’t assign tasks to people!”, “Don’t tell the team how to do something!” or “Don’t make decisions the team can make on their own!”.

The two most common (and both potentially harmful) consequences of this are that the leader backs off and stops doing anything or the leader keeps doing the same things exactly the same way as before.

How do we address this then? How does effective leadership work in a 21st century organization?

Five key principles of agile leadership

Individuals and organizations are not machines, but living organisms who need to learn and adapt. This means that we cannot always have pre-programmed rules to follow. Pre-programmed rules and predefined processes work well in a stable environment, where we are able to predict all possible scenarios and prepare in advance to handle them. But what about the scenarios or disruptive changes we cannot predict?

In such a context, it is more effective to learn and rely on principles instead of rules. First we need to incorporate those principles into our decision-making and leadership styles. Then, when new circumstances unfold, we can define appropriate practices, aligned with those principles, to make use of.

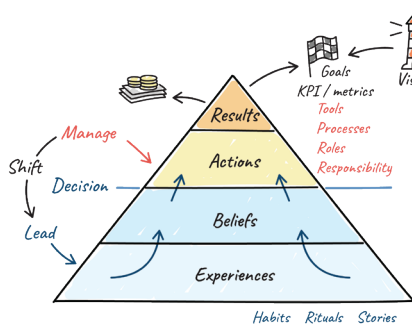
A good analogy for this is parenting. When kids are small, we can give them specific rules to follow, which work well in the safe space of the family home: “Don’t put your fingers into the plug! Sit well! First, finish your homework and then you can use your mobile phone!” However, if we want them to grow up and be equipped to face the unexpected events of adult life, we need to stop giving them rules and start teaching them principles. An example would be

“Be honest”. Only then will they be able to handle different and unpredictable situations well.

So what are useful agile leadership principles to incorporate?

1. Manage the environment, not the people

Research and empirical evidence show that we can't change people: we can hardly change the person we see in the mirror every morning. But we can change the environment and people's experiences so that the behaviors and the results we expect are likely to come to life.



Every organization has a vision and sets goals and metrics to monitor on the way to that company vision. Those goals are achieved (or not) through the results that every single person in the organization accomplishes. Some of them are exciting, like bringing an innovative product to market, and some of them are just necessary, like filling in tax returns. But all results come from actions and behaviors. Going

one level deeper, actions come from decisions, which in turn are informed by beliefs: we decide based on what we think is right or wrong in a particular moment.

Our brains are connecting machines, which create wired patterns through which we interpret the reality around us and decide what is right or wrong. These patterns are created through the experiences we have lived. Existing patterns cannot be broken: the power of one to one conversations is therefore overrated. But new patterns can be created through novel experiences.

Traditional leaders tend to focus on managing people's actions. This approach addresses just the tip of the iceberg, and it only works well in a very stable environment. In such a state, the rate of change is so slow that we can afford to have only a few people, such as managers, in charge of making decisions and let the rest of the workforce execute those decisions.

When the rate of change is high, the reaction from hierarchical management is too slow and can create bottlenecks. Here, decision-making power must be distributed and given to those closer to the problems. To avoid the risk that everyone takes their own direction, this distributed decision-making power needs to be coherently funneled towards the company goals and vision.

Organizational culture is so much more than a value statement on a company website: it's the sum of the experiences and beliefs of the people involved. The organizational culture can be measured through its living manifestations, such as rituals, stories of success and failure, habits, and unwritten rules.

Today, an effective leader does not demand superficial compliance to company values, but leverages approaches such as mentorship and coaching to create new experiences, which will then result in new stories, new rituals and new behaviors.

Agile leadership focuses on the bottom of the pyramid to manage the environment and create those experiences for people to build coherent beliefs, which will in turn determine coherent decisions.

2. Build autonomy and trust

Modern day organizations benefit from decentralized decision-making. To be more resilient and equipped to face unexpected circumstances, they must be built upon autonomous and self-managed teams.



But as we said above, the shift from a hierarchical chain of command to autonomy cannot be pushed onto people overnight. Individuals and teams need to be respectfully guided over time to become more autonomous and agile, by adapting to the leadership and the environment iteratively and incrementally.

An agile leader carefully selects those leadership behaviors that can act as a bridge in the gentle transition towards higher levels of autonomy with minimum disruption and resistance.

This process of transition and discovery will be shaped by bringing diverse perspectives together, for instance by asking people to share stories of success and failure. Some questions you could ask include:

- Do they associate stories of success and failure with the same leadership approach or with different ones?
- What behaviors from the leader do they associate with success or failure?
- Is the group uncomfortable with higher autonomy at a given moment or do they favor it?

A transition towards a higher level of autonomy while building trust (instead of harming it) is based on adopting iteratively and incrementally more of the behaviors that are associated with the desired state and less of the ones that are not.

At the same time, it is necessary to build the teams' skills to sustain high levels of autonomy, for instance the ability to navigate conflicts, collective decision-making, and the ability to give each other constructive feedback.

3. Model the behaviors you want to see

As agile leaders shape the environment to create the experiences which support the right culture and make higher levels of autonomy accepted and affordable by the team, they realize they are also part of that environment.



This means that they need to own and model the culture they want to see in the organization, to ensure that what they preach matches the leadership behavior they demonstrate. A mismatch can undermine people's trust and willingness to take on more responsibility.

If agile leaders are serious about improving their organization, they should be even more serious about improving themselves.

4. Lead based on the context

The ability to make sense of the circumstances in a given situation and adapt the approach to match the context is a key characteristic of good leadership. As expressed by Dave Snowden in the Cynefin framework, different circumstances can be associated with different domains. The domains, in turn, are characterized by different approaches to decision-making, acting and leading.



Situations in ordered domains show causality, meaning there is a clear relationship between cause and effect. This means that we can plan and act, based on the characteristics of the situation and the context in which it is happening. In some cases, the appropriate action is self-evident: it is sufficient and effective just to tell people what to do or establish guidelines and checklists to follow. Other cases require analysis. In these situations, expertise plays a very important role: the leader will ask experts to analyze the situation, and produce different options for responding. Establishing expert peer review can improve the quality of what is decided and executed.

In unordered domains, the lack of causality makes planning and the direct reuse of existing approaches very difficult, if not impossible. When the situation is complex, the relationship between cause and effect can only be discovered in hindsight and therefore actions might have unintended consequences. In those cases, expertise is not of much help, and it is necessary to run multiple parallel probes, some of which will fail. These allow for identifying repeating patterns and show us how to address the problem effectively. The leader's ability to involve cognitively diverse people will affect the quality of the experiments and the decided actions.

In a chaotic situation, such as an emergency, the leader's ability to act promptly is what will make a difference. Waiting and trying to analyze the situation is useless when volatility and uncertainty are very high.

Understanding the context and the situation allows leaders to act

effectively in a given cultural context. For example, in a hierarchical organization people will expect the leader to appoint experts and make the final decision in a complicated situation, while in a more collaborative organization, the group will feel comfortable to appoint experts and options on how to move forward will be vetted and discussed by the group. Agile leaders are aware of the context and the situation and how to appropriately shift their behaviors and modulate the course of action.

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5. Incorporate agility into change

All changes, even with the best intentions, can create motivational debt by introducing gaps between expectations and reality. There is only so much change one person can



handle at a time. However, many organizations try to take a “fail-safe” approach to change. An example of this could be buying a big model from a consulting agency, marketing the concept internally, and setting milestones. There’s so much money, ego and expectations attached to the change project that it will simply not be allowed to fail.

Agile leaders, on the other hand, know that effective change in a complex environment can only work with an evolutionary approach. Here, the focus is on leveraging the potential of the present and the natural predispositions that already exist in a team or an organization, instead of pushing towards an unrealistic ideal state.

Again, it is like parenting. If we want our kids to learn collaboration, we don’t describe what good collaboration looks like and create a plan towards it. Instead, we might encourage them to join a football team or to join an orchestra, depending on what they like most. Through these experiences, they will build collaboration muscles and learn what collaboration is all about.

In order to reduce the risk and side effects of change within organizations and deal with unpredictability, effective leaders know to instill change through diverse experiments with small continuous adaptations. This removes the burden and risk of maintaining different co-existing systems of work (i.e. the old way of working, and the new one) for

long periods of time: small changes are easily understood, quickly piloted and rapidly integrated, minimizing the uncertainty, confusion and loss of effectiveness inherent in change.

Running different parallel experiments enables leaders to validate assumptions and hypotheses in a safe-to-fail environment. Through multiple safe-to-fail experiments they recognize repeating emergent patterns that can be replicated to catalyze change in other parts of the organization.

By asking volunteers to help define and run the experiments, they achieve wider acceptance of the change in the organization and increase transparency because everyone can see small things happening, and help the organization move in that direction: people hate it when a big change is unexpectedly announced by management and they cannot relate to the rationale and the implications of the change.

Agile Leadership Behaviors

Agile leadership is, at its core, the ability to master multiple leadership behaviors to be able to adopt the one that fits the specific context and the team's expectations.

Six leadership styles to master

We can define six different behaviors that can be developed and applied in different contexts and cultures.

Directing



The leader acts, and is perceived as, an expert and an authority. They are therefore in charge of assigning and controlling work while being held accountable for the results of the group's work. Discussion or negotiation is usually not welcome when leading in this way. Instead, the leader expects compliance from their followers.

When it works: This behavior is essential in a crisis or when people expect clear direction.

When it doesn't: When people expect a certain degree of autonomy, a directing style can be stifling and cause frustration.

What holds the group together: The direct relationship with the leader, as well as a shared awareness of the possible consequences of failure.

Demanding



The leader is perceived and acts as someone with extremely high standards. They are competitive and focus primarily on performance, while leading by example. The followers focus on their targets.

When it works: When followers perceive the work as focused on results, a constant push from the leader can be motivating in the short term.

When it doesn't: When used long-term, this style can cause a high level of stress.

What holds the group together: Meeting targets successfully as well as the leader's conflict-solving skills.

Conducting



The leader coordinates and encourages collaboration, believing that collaboration is essential and increases quality. While the leader is responsible for enabling the collaboration, the followers feel responsible for their individual contribution. They can rely on help from their peers.

When it works: When followers know that they need to deliver the work, but expect the leader to retain the overall responsibility for delivering

value, conducting can be effective.

When it doesn't: This behavior can cause problems when people do not feel comfortable organizing their own work, or when they are not skillful enough to handle disagreements that emerge from cooperation.

What holds the group together: Clear roles and responsibilities as well as healthy group dynamics.

Envisioning



The leader motivates people by providing a compelling and challenging vision of the future. They inspire collaboration and a sense of shared responsibility. They have faith in their followers' abilities. The followers value collaboration and they are motivated by their feeling of being able to learn and achieve more together.

When it works: This style is great for when the team believes that quality work can be achieved only through collaboration and collective agreement.

When it doesn't: If the team does not have sufficient skills in collaborative decision-making, this can cause difficulties.

What holds the group together: A team identity and a shared purpose that motivates each individual team member.

Coaching



The leader supports team members with their personal growth and increases team effectiveness by being a servant leader. The team shares responsibility and collaborates to achieve their goals. They are motivated by mastering challenges and learning continuously.

When it works: When the followers perceive the work as being self-directed and expect a high level of autonomy in achieving their goals.

When it doesn't: When the followers do not feel comfortable with autonomy or do not have appropriate skills in giving or receiving constructive peer-to-peer feedback.

What holds the group together: A sense of belonging as well as the challenge of reaching their full potential both individually and as a team.

Catalyzing



The leader amplifies the success of the team, connects them with the rest of the organization and ensures their contribution to strategy creation.

The leader provides both praise and challenges and enables synergies. The followers are self-governing, maximize value delivery and incorporate customer feedback autonomously. They are open-minded, curious and adaptive. They are motivated by their contribution.

When it works: When the followers perceive their work as fully self-managed in terms of both the goal and how to achieve it.

When it doesn't: When people are only focused on their own personal or team success and are unable to see the benefits of collaborating with the larger organization.

What holds the group together: A constant search for new challenges.

Because of the dependence on context, expectations and relationships, there are no leadership behaviors that are inherently positive or negative. It is more helpful to describe leadership behaviors as either more or less helpful within a specific situation. The way the leadership behavior is perceived by those affected is important in a given cultural context.

For example, being an agile leader does not mean using a coaching leadership behavior in every circumstance since this can be unhelpful, or even harmful, in certain situations. An example is a crisis

situation, or working with people that expect specific directives. In both of these examples, a leader being directive or demanding can be a gold example of servant leadership. This is because they are intentionally adopting that behavior in a specific moment in service of empowering them to be better and more autonomous.

How do you know which leadership behavior is most appropriate?

When you think of switching between leadership behaviors, it may seem like a tough challenge and even a little overwhelming at first. Agile leaders use emotional intelligence and are conscious of their own and other people's emotions and perspectives. This helps them to adopt the appropriate leadership behavior in different circumstances. They are able to gently and gradually shift their default leadership behavior from directing towards coaching and catalyzing, in order to increase agility and autonomy in their team and organization. This is a skill, and like any skill, it can be learned, practiced and mastered.

Agile Metrics for Leadership

A question on many agile leaders' minds is, "How do we know how well we are doing as leaders?" To be able to answer this question we could measure the impact that our leadership has on the autonomy of our team, the culture and the resilience of our organization. However, these are all lagging indicators which we can evaluate only in hindsight: sometimes leadership is like planting seeds of a tree we will never enjoy the shade of.

However, we could also look at a few leading indicators to understand whether we are going in the right direction and get feedback. In this way we will be able to improve by leveraging our strengths and acting on our improvement areas.

Leading indicators for effective leadership

Servant Leadership

A first leading metric could be around how we are doing as servant leaders. When we demonstrate servant leadership, we are likely to be strengthening people's skills and building leadership as a diffused organizational capability, so that everyone can be a potential leader. A few questions can help us self-reflect on the different servant leadership virtues and their impact on the people around us:

- Do people believe that I am willing to sacrifice my own self-interest for the good of the group?
- Do people believe that I want to hear their ideas and will value them?
- Do people believe that I understand what is happening in their lives and how it affects them?
- Do people come to me when chips are down or when something traumatic has happened in their lives?
- Do others believe that I have a strong sense of awareness for what is going on?
- Do others follow my requests because they want to and not because they have to?
- Do others communicate their ideas and vision for the organization when I am around?
- Do others have confidence in my ability to anticipate the future and its consequences?
- Do others believe that I am preparing the organization to make a positive difference in the world?
- Do people believe that I am committed to helping them develop and grow?
- Do people feel a strong sense of community in the organization that I lead?

Once you identify your biggest strength and your biggest improvement area, meet with a

peer and:

1. Share a story describing a situation where you demonstrated the servant leadership virtue you believe represents your biggest strength
2. Ask for a suggestion what to do tomorrow to become one inch better at practicing the virtue you feel you are struggling most with

Mastering multiple leadership behaviors

Another useful leading indicator could be about our ability to master multiple leadership behaviors. If we are able to adopt the appropriate leadership behavior in each situation or context, we can reduce motivational debt and grow autonomy and resilience in the organization. A leadership behavior assessment can help us reflect and show us how to strengthen our leadership muscles.

Our leadership behavior assessment is based on SenseMaker® technology developed by Dave Snowden and The Cynefin Co. Both the leader and their followers capture and interpret situations in which the leader demonstrated a certain behavior. Multiple perspectives on the same situation help the leader realize how well they master different leadership behaviors and how coherently they apply those to different situations and contexts.

Lean Leadership

The term lean leadership is somewhat of a buzzword. However, if you unpack it, there are a lot of useful principles behind it.

What does lean mean?

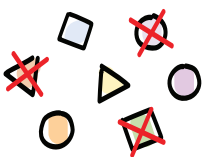
The term lean was coined by James Womack, Daniel T. Jones and Daniel Roos in their book, *The Machine That Changed the World: The Story of Lean Production*, in 1990. They used the word to capture the essence of their in-depth study of the famous Toyota Production System (TPS). Back then, the term and its principles applied primarily to production.

Later, in 2003, Mary and Tom Poppendieck published the book *Lean Software Development: An Agile Toolkit*. In this book they identified seven fundamental principles to apply lean thinking to software and product development, or any creative work.

The seven lean principles

Each of the seven principles the Poppendiecks proposed has implications on leadership.

Eliminate waste

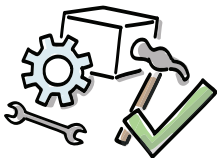


Waste is defined as any activity which does not add value to the customer. The first step towards eliminating waste is simply to see the waste. The leader should know how the value flows in the organization and continuously challenge the current practice in order to identify any waste.

This is not enough though. A lean leader helps the team remove any impediments that they are not able to resolve without support. They design or optimize sustainable solutions in organizations to prevent the same impediment from coming back again. Finally, as in a famous quote from W.E. Deming, an American statistician who influenced a lot of the thinking behind the TPS, a lean leader realizes that *“The greatest waste [...] is failure to use the abilities of people [...] to learn about their frustrations and about the contributions that they are eager to make”*.

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Build quality in



A lean leader works to build a culture of discipline and excellence, guides others using principles and values instead of complex rules. They teach people not to cut corners, challenge coworkers to deliver great quality work, and lead by example. You might argue that this is just true leadership – and it is.

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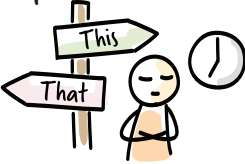
Amplify learning



Traditional managers face competition with other managers trying to meet goals focused on local optimization and to look good to their own managers. This wastes a lot of organizational learning which could be leveraged by collaborating with peers instead. Building and maintaining a network of peers is essential, as well as continuously challenging one's own leadership approach in the light of what works and what doesn't. Amplifying learning also implies:

- Encouraging safe-to-fail experiments and fast feedback loops
- Providing and being open to feedback
- Striving for transparency to control the complex system each organization is

Defer commitment



Keep your options open up to the last responsible moment and be capable of living with uncertainty, because that is the reality we are facing. Early commitment could mean discarding potentially good options, just not to afford the cost of deferring a decision.

Deliver as fast as possible



The most effective way of addressing a complex problem is to let a diverse team of skilled people self-organize and decide how to approach the situation through experimentation. A team is able to self-organize around a goal when the leader helps define what the goal is, makes it compelling and clarifies what constraints the environment has. If you want to help your team or organization to deliver as fast as possible, set a clear vision, explain clearly where to go and why, align all stakeholders around that vision and encourage fast feedback. Finally, give space to your teams to reflect on what they are doing to find ways to go even faster.

“If you’re not a front line engineer, there’s only one reason for you to exist: help your team move faster” - Jan Bosch

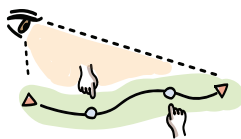
Respect people



Who dares to disagree with this? This apparently generic statement hides a deeper meaning: Give people the environment and support they need to do a great job and trust they will do their best to accomplish their goal. So it's not simply about saying to a team "Now you're empowered

to do what you want", but creating the conditions for them to succeed. It's about staying close to the teams, Managing By Walking Around and Listening, motivating them and assisting with their personal development. That might require teaching, mentoring and coaching.

optimize the whole



Optimizing the whole means having an end to end view of the system, product or organization and consequently selecting the right metrics which can help the system improve. It is about measuring only what adds value (less is more).

Whatever you want to measure, do so from a perspective one level above what you are trying to look at to avoid

getting bogged down in detail. Rather than individual performance, focus on team performance, for an overview of your teams, consider the larger organization.

Three dimensions of lean leadership

What else can we learn from organizational transformations and lean management in manufacturing? There are three dimensions worth considering as a leader.

Visible problems do not exist, they have been solved already

A few years ago, during a seminar on Lean Management and Continuous Improvement, the CEO of a consulting company, owned by the Japanese government, held a talk about the Toyota Production System. He defined three categories for problems: potential, invisible and visible. He pointed out the importance of identifying potential problems to the desired target as well as making invisible problems visible and improving immediately. Visible

problems do not actually exist, because they have been solved already.

For your personal reflection: How many clearly visible problems are you still stuck with in your organization?

The most efficient way becomes standard, the standard must be improved every month

In a panel about Continuous Improvement, one of the participants described how once a process had been improved in efficiency in one department, it then became a standard. That standard must be reviewed, visualized and each manager held accountable to improve the standard every month.

For your personal reflection: How much are you still striving to find one-size-fits-all best practices to make you move quickly to the next rigid and comfortable status quo? What are your managers accountable for?

Measure organizational capacity of solving impediments to generate trust

Being able to handle impediments plays a great role in any initiative to become more lean as an organization. The organizational capacity to solve impediments can be measured and visualized in a graph with two curves: the accumulated number of raised impediments per month and the accumulated number of fixed impediments per month. The two curves should always be parallel. If the curve of fixed impediments goes flat, all employees will see that leadership is not taking impediments seriously.

For your personal reflection: How serious is your organization about solving teams' impediments?

Agile Leadership Training

In a post from 2011, consultant and author Esther Derby explains how insufficient training and mentoring can be damaging for leaders. She says, *“Most people in management roles receive little or no training on how to do the job. Many organizations promote people who excelled as individual contributors doing technical work into management roles [...] The skills required for management are often vastly different. [...] A lot of the management training out there is crap. Few organizations have robust and confidential mentorship programs.”*

As we discussed in the chapters above, an effective way to become a better agile leader is to self-assess your servant leadership skills, understand how good you are at mastering multiple leadership behaviors, and grow your emotional intelligence through journaling, self-reflection, and feedback.

However, a solid education is extremely important, especially if you are starting the journey or want to deepen and practice your agile leadership skills. In this context the industry standard and most widely recognized program in agile leadership is Certified Agile Leadership Essentials for Team and Organization Leaders, also known as CAL-E+T+O training. This class will help you discover how your natural, cultural dispositions might affect your teams, and learn how to create a safe-to-fail environment that fosters a culture of creativity, transparency, inspection and adaptation.

The three day program is structured in three parts:

1. Bring awareness and understanding of the foundations of agile leadership
2. Create awareness about the changing dynamics in today's world of work and equip leaders with the practices they need to effectively lead their teams
3. Bring awareness to the practices and principles of agility and how they apply to sustainable business and organizational agility

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Contributors and acknowledgements

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